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FLOOD ALERT IN UTTAR PRADESH AND BIHAR, ADDITIONAL NDRF TEAMS DEPLOYED

Over 100 Indians among hundreds missing in Nepal flash flood fury

Most Indians were headed to Kailash Mansarovar; death toll crosses 150, likely to climb

Yubaraj Ghimire
Kathmandu, August 26

OVER 150 people were killed while at least 484, including 105 Indians and 37 Non-Resident Indians (NRIs), were reported missing after massive flash floods in Nepal’s districts bordering Tibet on Wednesday.

According to official figures, 391 foreign nationals and 93 from Nepal had been reported missing until 7 pm (local time). These included at least 60 working in hydel projects in the area.

Sources said most of the Indians reported missing were headed to Kailash Mansarovar.

The remaining tourists are from the United States, Malaysia, United Kingdom, South Africa, Australia and the Netherlands.

Among the dead were 44 from Nepal’s Army, 28 from the police and 13 from the Armed Police Force. The authorities fear higher casualties and widespread destruction.

Initial reports from the affected areas and the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said the border river flood, which began a little after 9 am local time, swept away many settlements across the 60-km road from Gyirong in Tibet, down to Rasuwa and Dhading districts in Nepal, both bordering Tibet, and Nuwakot district.

With these areas being part of Nepal’s old trade route with Tibet, they are thickly

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RELATED REPORTS, P.7,14

Russia turns to India to meet petrol demand after oil infra takes a hit in Ukraine strikes

Imports 1 million barrels in two months

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, August 26

THE DAMAGE caused by Ukrainian strikes to its oil refining infrastructure has forced Russia — one of the biggest crude producers and refiners globally — to import gasoline, or petrol, including from faraway India.

While a bulk of Russian imports of petrol are from neighbouring Belarus and Kazakhstan, India is estimated to have dispatched over 1 million barrels over June and July, ship tracking data indicates. According to experts, this is the first instance of Russia impor-

ting petrol from India.

Trade sources said the trend has likely continued in August as well, although data is not yet available. Nayara Energy’s Vadinar refinery — which has significant Russian shareholding — is the main Indian supplier, they said. Meanwhile, large volumes of Russian crude continue to arrive in India to feed Indian refineries, including the Nayara Energy facility, which means that some of the gasoline being supplied to Russia is being derived from its own oil refined in India.

This marks a change in the

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



A videograb of the devastating flash floods in Nepal on Wednesday; at least five districts have been affected. PTI

Ice-rock avalanche may have triggered surge in border river, say experts

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, August 26

SCIENTISTS FROM the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD), along with partner institutions in Nepal and China, are investigating whether an ice-rock avalanche from a high-altitude area could be the trigger for the flash floods and mudslide on the Nepal-Tibet border on Wednesday.

ICIMOD is a Nepal-based intergovernmental institution leading the global effort to protect the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH) region.

“Preliminary assessment based on video footage and information from affected areas suggest that a large volume of ice and rock debris may have entered the Lhende Khola, a tributary of the Bhote Koshi river. Researchers say the event could have generated a sudden surge that carried water, sediment and large boulders downstream,” ICIMOD said in a press release on Wednesday evening.

Early analysis of seismic records has also identified unusual signals recorded during the period of the disaster, but

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WROTE THREE LETTERS TO CJI WITH COPIES TO COLLEGIUM

SC judge accuses Rajasthan HC Acting Chief Justice of ‘misuse of powers’, demands his transfer

Justice Sandeep Mehta says he got ‘several complaints’ which ‘raise doubts’ on judge’s ‘integrity’

Ananthakrishnan G & Hamza Khan
New Delhi, Jaipur, August 26

IN A highly unusual development, Justice Sandeep Mehta of the Supreme Court wrote three letters to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant earlier this month, seeking the transfer of Justice S P Sharma, Acting Chief Justice of Rajasthan High Court, to another High Court and the appointment of a new Chief Justice.

In his letters to the CJI — these were written on August 2, August 10 and August 17 and also copied to other members of the Supreme Court Collegium — Justice Mehta accused Justice Sharma of “misuse of powers” and said he had received “several complaints” which “raise doubts” on the Acting CJ’s “integrity”.

Justice Mehta, who also hails from Rajasthan, requested that Justice Sharma be “forthwith transferred out of

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Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta; (right) Acting Chief Justice of Rajasthan High Court Justice S P Sharma

CJI seeks comments from ‘both sides’ while Collegium considers appointments to HCs

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, August 26

CHIEF JUSTICE of India Surya Kant has sought comments from “both sides” in the matter involving Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta and Rajasthan High Court Acting Chief Justice S P Sharma.

Justice Mehta had written to the CJI, seeking the transfer of Justice Sharma and the appointment of a permanent Chief Justice from another High Court. In his letters, Justice Mehta alleged “gross maladministration”, misuse of ad-

ministrative powers and favouritism in the functioning of the Rajasthan High Court.

It is learnt that the CJI sought comments because allegations were being made by both sides. Sources familiar with the developments said the Collegium was already deliberating on the appointment of Chief Justices to the remaining High Courts.

The CJI’s office issued a statement, underlining that he had “taken note of the concerns raised in the letters” written by Justice Mehta while “stressing

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

India, China to advance boundary talks for ‘early harvest’, set up new LAC meeting points, hotlines

Delhi, Beijing list eight outcomes of meeting between Doval and Wang

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 26

INDIA AND China have decided to advance discussions on “an early and substantial harvest” of boundary delimitation and border management, and agreed on two new border military hotlines in the eastern and middle sectors, two new meeting points for military commander-level meetings, and on holding the trans-border river meeting next month.

These form part of eight outcomes and consensus after the Special Representative-level talks between National Secur-



NSA Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing, Tuesday. PTI FILE

ity Advisor Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi in Beijing Tuesday.

A statement released Wednesday by both the Ministry of External Affairs and the Chinese Foreign Ministry spoke of eight outcomes and consensus reached after the 25th round of talks between the Special Representatives where there was a candid and in-depth exchange

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INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 27~08~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or

indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing

of other topics in the main exam.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Nepal

populated. Rasuwa is known for its trekking routes, with 108 lakes in the region including the sacred Gosaikunda Lake. Some of the missing were trekking to the Gosaikunda Lake, coinciding with the local festival of Janai Purnima on Friday.

Though the monsoon season is less favorable for trekking in Nepal, it's a major season for Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, along the Rasuwa (Nepal)-Gyirong (Tibet) route.

Dozens of multi-storied buildings, trucks and vans were buried under the mud in Nuwakot, one of the worst-affected areas. Critical infrastructure, including at least a dozen hydro-power projects, was also destroyed, affecting about 700 MW of power generation. Gorkha, Nawalparasi and Chitwan were among the other districts affected.

Climate experts at the Kathmandu-based International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) said an avalanche from a glacier likely caused the flash floods. Initial reports suggested that an earthquake in the area could have triggered an avalanche and caused

the floods, Nepal's Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal also told Parliament on Wednesday, according to local media reports.

"Preliminary assessment based on video footage and information from affected areas suggest that a large volume of ice and rock debris may have entered the Lhende Khola, a tributary of the Bhote Koshi River. Researchers say the event could have generated a sudden surge that carried water, sediment and large boulders downstream," ICIMOD said in a press release.

From its origin in Tibet, the Bhote Koshi river empties into Nepal's Trishuli river that eventually flows into India as the Gandak river. The swollen Trishuli river engulfed the surrounding areas, leaving a wide swathe of destruction on either side of its course. At least half-a-dozen bridges over the river were swept away, including in the Malekhu area, affecting connectivity to the two tourist sites of Chitwan and Pokhara.

Security footage captured on the Chinese side of the Nepal-Tibet border showed many people fleeing before a torrent of rock, mud and water destroyed buildings, vehicles and took many lives.

China's official Xinhua news agency said the mudslide oc-

curred on the Nepal side and hit the Gyirong port, cutting roads, communication and power links in the Shigatse region near the border, but did not elaborate.

Chinese state broadcaster CCTV said the mudslide in Gyirong County near the border killed at least three and left 265 missing. A rescuer told CCTV that it would take at least four hours for the team to reach the site due to the 1.5-metre deep sediment that blocked pathways leading to the affected area. The debris had surged upstream from the Nepalese side of the crossing, the rescuer said.

The exact cause of the mudslide could not be immediately determined, but the German Research Centre for Geosciences said there was a 4.4 magnitude quake around seven minutes before the time shown on the security footage time-stamp.

An initial study of Planet Lab satellite imagery indicated that a landslide of snow and rock triggered a debris-laden flood in the Lhende Khola, about 20 km northeast of the Nepal-China Rasuwagadhi border crossing, Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority said on X.

An ice-rock avalanche in the Lhende Khola on the Nepal side was the trigger, but the cause re-

mains unconfirmed, said Qiang-gong Zhang, head of climate and environmental risks, at ICIMOD. "With a blockage still lodged upstream on the Nepal-China border river, authorities warn a second flood may occur," Qiang-gong said.

Prime Minister Balendra Shah called an emergency meeting of the Cabinet. "Instructions have been given... to move the people living in the lower areas to safer places," he said.

Former King Gyanendra Shah also issued an appeal, calling for a coordinated safety campaign and tripartite cooperation between Nepal, India and China for long-term initiatives to contain floods. Last August too, the same regions in Nepal had seen similar flash floods when a glacial lake in Tibet overflowed because of high temperatures. Nine people were killed, and critical infrastructure, including a bridge connecting Nepal and China, was damaged at the time.

"The Lhende Khola has flooded twice in fourteen months, this time triggered by an ice-rock avalanche from a glacier on the Nepal side that blocked the river and released a sudden surge downstream," said Saswata Sanyal, a disaster risk reduction specialist at the climate research group. **WITH AGENCIES**

Russia

energy relationship between Moscow and New Delhi. For about four years now, India has been one of the top two buyers of Russian crude, the other being China. Russian oil, often sold at attractive prices after Western sanctions disrupted Moscow's traditional European markets in the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, now accounts for the lion's share in India's crude import basket.

Repeated Ukrainian drone attacks on Russian oil refineries, combined with routine refinery maintenance, strong summer season demand, and logistical bottlenecks, have compounded the problems for Moscow. Domestic supplies of both petrol and diesel are impacted, but the country is still relatively comfortable with regard to diesel as its refining system is geared to produce far more diesel than its consumption.

Nevertheless, Moscow has responded with restrictions on diesel exports as well in a bid to have a comfortable cushion ahead of the winter season. Petrol, however, is a different story. Exports are out of the question and reports indicate that limits have been placed on the volume of petrol that can be supplied to a vehicle across numerous fuel stations in various regions of the country.

"Gasoline has been particularly exposed. Under normal operating conditions, Russian refinery output broadly covers domestic demand with only limited surplus available for exports, leaving the market with relatively little buffer when refinery throughput falls... With refinery runs remaining de-

pressed, Russia has responded by restricting product exports and played with product specifications across several barrels to protect domestic availability," Sumit Ritolia, modelling and refining manager at commodity market analytics provider Kpler told The Indian Express.

As per Kpler data, about 12,000 barrels per day (bps) of gasoline was exported from India to Russia in June, with the volumes jumping to about 21,000 bpd in July. Taken together, this amounts to close to a million barrels of petrol being sent to Russia during the two months. Additionally, some additional volumes are expected to have reached Russia from India through a series of ship-to-ship transfers and vessels with undeclared destinations.

"Most of the imported gasoline has come from Belarus. One of Belarus's two refineries is 42% owned by a Russian consortium, and all the crude processed at both of them comes from Russia. Kazakhstan would be another nearby option, but it cannot supply significant volumes...(it) is a net importer. The seaborne trade is more interesting. So far, Russia appears to have received five gasoline cargoes... Three of them were cargoes of around 320,000-350,000 barrels from Vadinar," Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona told this newspaper.

Another cargo arrived via Morocco's Tangier terminal, although its original source is unclear as Morocco does not have an active refinery. Another cargo of around 250,000 barrels was shipped from Turkey's Mersin port. Katona said that while there is no refinery near Mersin, a 500,000-barrel cargo from India had been discharged there about a week earlier.

Supreme Court judge

the State looking to his unbecoming conduct" and that not doing so would be "wholly against the interest of the Institution".

Phone calls to the Registrar General of the Rajasthan High Court for comment did not elicit a response.

Incidentally, on April 25 this year, Ranjeet Joshi, president of the Rajasthan High Court Advocates Association of Jodhpur, wrote to the CJI, urging him to consider the transfer of Justice Sharma "outside the state of Rajasthan... so that a harmonious atmosphere can be re-established between the Bar and the Bench".

Seeking the appointment of a permanent Chief Justice, Joshi said, "The lack of communication and treatment of advocates is leading to frequent disagreements and conflicts between the Bar and the Bench, which is detrimental to the smooth functioning of the Bar and the Bench. Furthermore, there are also issues regarding the basic needs of advocates, such as providing small chambers/meeting spaces (e.g., 10x10 feet tin sheds), for which the expected cooperation is not being received, due to which there is dissatisfaction among the advocates."

Elevated to the Rajasthan High Court in 2016, Justice Sharma was transferred to the Patna High Court in 2022. In 2023, the Supreme Court Colle-

gium turned down his request that he be sent back to Rajasthan on health grounds and instead moved him to the Punjab and High Court. In 2025, the Collegium accepted his request following which he became Acting CJ of the Rajasthan High Court.

Justice Mehta alleged that "pursuant to taking charge as the Acting Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court, Mr. Justice Sharma has exhibited total lack of leadership qualities and behaviour unbecoming of a leader of the institution on more than one occasions."

"Several instances where cases listed in other rosters were suddenly withdrawn by exercising powers of the master of the roster and shifted to the Bench of Mr. Justice S P Sharma without any justifiable cause and orders were passed raising serious question mark on the integrity of the decision-making process," he wrote to the CJI.

"There are innumerable instances of Mr Justice Sharma, exercising powers as the Acting Chief Justice in a manner unbecoming of the leader of the institution... I have received several complaints about the judicial functioning of Mr Justice S P Sharma which, prima facie, raise doubts on his integrity," he alleged.

In one of the letters, Justice Mehta also spoke about the "humiliation" he had to suffer after being invited to a conference in Jaipur from July 31 to August 2.

Justice Mehta said Supreme Court judge Justice Vijay Bishnoi and he "were both invited to the conference and gave consent for being present in the inaugural session which was to be headed by" the CJI.

"However, the invitation card issued by the Rajasthan State Legal Services Authority does not bear any reference whatsoever to our names. What is more humiliating is even though my consent was taken to speak in the inaugural session but the minute-to-minute programme placed on the dais did not indicate so. Having noticed this, I immediately texted my Private Secretary to speak to the coordinating officer, i.e., the Member Secretary, Rajasthan State Legal Services Authority, who came to the dais after a few minutes and placed an amended programme, tendering a formal apology. Apparently, this was a deliberate attempt of humiliating the sitting Judges of the Supreme Court whose parent High Court is the Rajasthan High Court," he said.

"On 1st August, 2026, after I had left Jaipur, I was informed that the programme was already scheduled to lay a foundation stone for a Guest House at the Rajasthan High Court Bench at Jaipur. It is shocking that the foundation stone of a building of significant importance was to be laid in the Rajasthan High Court and yet, both Supreme Court Judges from Rajasthan, i.e., myself and Mr. Justice Vijay Bishnoi, even though present at Jaipur, were neither informed nor invited to participate

therein. It is not that this event was organised out of the blue or cropped up at the last moment. Invitation cards were printed and preparations were made in advance but deliberately the names of both the Judges of the Supreme Court hailing from Rajasthan were excluded from the function. This is grave intentional humiliation towards which I register my strong protest," he said.

In another letter, Justice Mehta accused Justice Sharma of "indulging in rampant nepotism and favouritism having taken advantage of the fact that he has been permitted to continue in the position of the Acting Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court for more than the last 10 months." He said it was "beyond comprehension... why such a long rope has been given to" the Acting CJ.

It cited messages from a sitting judge of the state High Court complaining about alleged "vindictive actions" by Justice Sharma against the judge's wife who is a judicial officer.

The letter also claimed Justice Sharma "unilaterally" sat over the inauguration of the newly constructed Jodhpur District Court (Metro) building for almost an year even though it was complete "and directed wholesale changes in the well-made infrastructure... The loss caused to the Institution by the irrational decision... is unpardonable".

Justice Mehta's letter also referred to instances of alleged favouritism shown by the Acting CJ to some lawyers and clients.

India, China

of views on the boundary question.

According to the statement, the two sides reaffirmed their commitment to "uphold the guidance received from the leaders of the two countries, maintain peace and tranquility in the border areas" and "create an atmosphere for healthy and steady development of bilateral relations".

The two sides underlined their commitment to "advancing negotiations on a framework for the settlement of the boundary question in accordance with the Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for Settlement of the China-India Boundary Question signed in 2005 and the consensus reached in subsequent SR talks, in pursuit of a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable solution," it stated.

"The Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation and Working Group on Border Management under the WMCC would respectively advance discussions on an Early and Substantial Harvest of boundary delimitation and Border Management. The first task for both these groups would be to agree on their respective Terms of Reference," the statement said on the third outcome. The WMCC is the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs.

Incidentally, when Doval and Wang held talks in New Delhi on August 19, 2025, days before PM Narendra Modi's visit to Tianjin for the SCO summit, they had decided to form an expert group under the WMCC to explore early harvest of the boundary delimitation, and a working group under the WMCC to advance effective border management.

On the fourth outcome of the Beijing meeting, the statement said: "The two sides agreed that any situation on the ground would be addressed promptly through existing diplomatic and military channels, including the WMCC, local commander-level meetings and other agreed mechanisms, to resolve outstanding issues and avoid misunderstanding and miscalculation." **Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RG0mljMzgl**

Ice-rock avalanche

there was no immediate causal link established between seismic activity and the flood.

"The same site devastated by last year's Rasuwa flood is once again under threat... An ice avalanche in the Lhende Khola is the suspected trigger, but the cause remains unconfirmed. With a blockage still lodged upstream on the Nepal-China border, authorities warn a second flood is imminent," Qiang-gong Zhang, head of Climate and Environmental Risks at ICIMOD, said in the press release.

An ice avalanche involves the sudden collapse and downhill movement of a large mass of ice from either a glacier that was

culuation along the LAC. The two sides discussed ways to improve understanding of the LAC in appropriate areas for better border management."

The fifth outcome stated: "With the objective to improve the border management measures, an additional two meeting points were agreed for holding the General Level Mechanism/Senior Highest Military Commander meeting (SHMC). Similarly, two additional channels of border military hotline in the Eastern and Middle Sectors were agreed."

Last year, the two sides had agreed on general level mechanisms in the eastern sector (Arunachal Pradesh) and middle sector (Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand), in addition to the existing mechanism in the western sector (Ladakh).

The sixth outcome of the meeting stated: "Both sides noted the progress on trans-border cooperation. The Indian side appreciated the efforts made by the Chinese side to increase the number of batches of Indian official pilgrimage Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra (KMY) in the Tibet Autonomous Region of China. Both sides appreciated the reopening of the three designated border trading points. The two sides agreed to strengthen exchanges and cooperation in border trade, pilgrimage and other areas, with the view to work together to create an atmosphere featuring dialogue, peace, consultation and cooperation in the border areas."

The Chinese Foreign Ministry statement described the Tibet Autonomous Region as "Mount Gang Renpoche and Lake Mapam Yun Tso in Xizang Autonomous Region of China".

The seventh outcome was that "the two sides agreed to hold the next meeting of the China-India Expert-Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers in September and maintain communication on issues including hydrological data sharing, and renewal of relevant MoUs."

This is especially important for the Brahmaputra, and timely sharing of data for river management.

Listing the eighth outcome, the statement said the two sides agreed to hold the 26th round of SR-level talks in India in 2027.

hanging or from an ice-covered mountain.

ICIMOD noted the "exceptional speed and magnitude" of the flood and added that the Trishuli river's water levels reportedly rose by nine metres at Galchhi and by seven metres at Malekhu within 30 minutes. Both these areas are part of Dhading district, one of the affected areas.

ICIMOD said experts are assessing whether debris temporarily blocked the river at a narrow section, forming a landslide dam. Such blockage, it said, could create a "secondary hazard" if impounded water is suddenly released.

CJI seeks comments

that allegations against a sitting judge must be dealt with strictly through the established institutional mechanism" and that "the Supreme Court cannot allow individual complaints concerning judges to be determined through competing claims in the media".

"The CJI maintained that the contents of the letters cannot be adjudicated in the public domain and that the concerned judge must be given a fair opportunity to place his response before any conclusion is reached. The fact that allegations have been made, therefore, cannot by itself be treated as a finding against the judge," the statement said.

Currently, seven of the 25 High Courts across the country have acting Chief Justices. On August 6, the Collegium recommended the appointment of Chief Justices to High Courts in Patna, Bombay, Calcutta and Punjab and Haryana. The Collegium is yet to make recommendations for Jammu and Kashmir, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan HCs.

It is learnt that Justice Sharma's candidature was "actively being considered" for appointment as Chief Justice of the Rajasthan HC. He has been Acting Chief Justice of his parent HC since September 28, 2025, the longest among the seven ACJs.

Incidentally, Justice Sharma was appointed as a HC judge on the same day as two other judges: Justice Pushpendra Singh Bhati and Justice Vinit Kumar Mathur. However, given his age, Justice Sharma took the oath of office first, establishing him higher in seniority. As per convention, the most senior judge is appointed acting Chief Justice. He is slated to retire on September 26, if not considered for elevation as a Supreme Court judge.

Before Justice Mehta's letters to the CJI became public, it is learnt that the judge had sought a meeting to discuss the issue. However, sources said that the CJI's travel schedule did not allow time for such a meeting.

The CJI, who is currently in Frankfurt, is scheduled to undertake a series of high-level judicial and legal engagements in Germany and the United Kingdom from August 26 to 30. His programme includes meetings with senior German judicial officials and participation in the Indo-German Arbitration Conclave in Berlin.

In the United Kingdom, the CJI is expected to attend the Commonwealth Policy Dialogue on Climate Justice in London and address the 43rd International Symposium on Economic Crimes at Cambridge University.



Delhi gets nodal cybercrime unit to tackle online frauds

The existing Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations (IFSO) Unit, Dwarka, will be subsumed into the D4C. Its investigation wing, digital investigation lab, training and awareness centre, the 1930 cyber helpline

The support centre will provide technical assistance to investigating officers across Delhi

The division will monitor, prevent and respond to cybersecurity threats affecting government systems, critical infrastructure and public digital assets.

Delhi SIR: Low-turnout seats in '25 polls may see more deletions

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 26

THE SPECIAL Intensive Revision (SIR) of Delhi's electoral rolls has produced a pattern at the draft stage: constituencies with lower voter turnout in the 2025 Assembly elections are more likely to have below-average digitisation rates, potentially putting a relatively higher share of their electorate at risk of exclusion from the draft electoral roll, an analysis by *The Indian Express* shows.

Delhi has 70 Assembly constituencies. An analysis of the data shows that 17 of the 18 constituencies with the lowest voter turnout in the 2025 elections — about a quarter of all Assembly seats — had digitisation rates below Delhi's average of 67%, data accessed by *The Indian Express* shows.

During the enumeration phase, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) go door to door to distribute enumeration forms, help electors fill them out, and collect the completed forms. The BLOs then upload the details to the Election Commission of India's (ECI) official portal, a process referred to as digitisation. The digitisation rate indicates the proportion of electors whose forms have been uploaded and who are likely to be included in the

• Turnout in 2025 Delhi Assembly elections

Constituency	Turnout %	Digitization rate %
Mehrauli	53	59
Model Town	53	63
R.K.Puram	54	56
Kasturba Nagar	54	56
Malviya Nagar	54	61
Karol Bagh	54	60
Kalkaji	54	57
Greater Kailash	55	65
Okhla	55	55
Wazirpur	56	63
Tughlakabad	56	52
Chandni Chowk	56	61
Timarpur	56	66
Adarsh Nagar	56	70
New Delhi	56	58
Badarpur	56.81	57
Jangpura	57.41	58
Rithala	57.71	64

SOURCE: ELECTION COMMISSION OF INDIA

draft electoral rolls.

Only Adarsh Nagar breaks the pattern, recording a turnout of 56% but a digitisation rate of nearly 70%.

Mehrauli, which recorded

the lowest turnout at 53%, has digitised around 59% of its electors. Kasturba Nagar, where turnout was 54%, has a digitisation rate of nearly 56%. In Tughlaqabad, turnout was 56%

and digitisation stands at around 52%.

The pattern is broadly consistent with the Election Commission's explanation for the SIR exercise: areas with a larger number of electors who have shifted, died or are otherwise ineligible may record lower turnout, and could also see a larger proportion of names classified as uncollectible during the revision. These constituencies are spread across Delhi and include both affluent neighbourhoods and lower-income areas.

Significantly, the analysis of data, however, does not support a similar pattern for constituencies with large Purvanchali or Muslim populations.

Of the 15 constituencies where Purvanchali voters are considered a dominant political force, seven have digitisation rates below the Delhi average while eight are above it. Sangam Vihar has a digitisation rate of 59%, Burari 61% and Rithala 64%. But other Purvanchali-dominated constituencies have significantly higher rates: Matiala stands at 76%, Dwarka at 72% and Babarpur at 73%.

The seven constituencies with a significant Muslim population also do not, as a group, show unusually low digitisation. Five have rates above the city average, while two fall

below it. Okhla has one of the lowest rates at nearly 55%, while Chandni Chowk stands at 61%. At the other end, Matia Mahal has digitised around 75% of its electors, Babarpur 73% and Mustafabad around 72%.

The final scale of exclusions, however, will not be known until the final electoral roll is published on November 4. The draft roll is scheduled to be published on August 31, after which voters whose names are missing can seek inclusion.

The enumeration phase ended last week. During the nearly one-and-a-half-month-long process, forms of around 97.51 lakh electors — 67% of the 1.45 crore electors initially on the rolls when the SIR exercise began in Delhi — had been collected and uploaded on the EC portal, according to data from the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Delhi.

The remaining 47.58 lakh electors, who constitute about 33% of the electorate, have been marked "uncollectible". The category includes electors who were absent, may have moved or died, duplicate entries and those listed under 'Other' reasons. Their names are set to be excluded from the draft roll, though the revision process will provide an opportunity to seek inclusion.

IIT-D revamps panel to probe student's death by suicide

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 26

AFTER IIT-DELHI agreed to change the composition of the committee that will inquire into the death by suicide of a Masters' student, the institute late Wednesday reconstituted the panel.

The protests began after Rishikesh Kumar, who was studying for an MSc in physics, allegedly jumped to his death from the sixth floor of a building on campus on Saturday.

The reconstituted committee is led by Justice Mukta Gupta, a retired judge of the Delhi High Court, serving as Chairperson. It also comprises Prof Pratap Sharan, Head of Department of Psychiatry at AIIMS New Delhi, alongside two yet-to-be-named student representatives and the IIT Delhi Registrar, who will function as the Secretary and Convenor.

Justice Mukta Gupta's appointment was among the demands made by the students.

The committee is tasked with discussing the incident with relevant students, faculty, and administrative branches, reviewing existing campus protocols, and submitting a final report with recommendations within two weeks.

IIT Director Rangan Banerjee made the announcement via an official email to faculty, students and all staff members on the intervening night of August 26-27.

The earlier panel comprised Ashok Kumar, the vice chancellor of the Sports University of Haryana who is an IIT-D alumnus and a former police chief of Uttarakhand; Pratap Sharma, head of the Department of Psychiatry at AIIMS, New Delhi; two student representatives, and the IIT-D Registrar who would be the secretary and convener of the committee.

But at their late-night meeting on Monday, the students objected to the presence of the former Uttarakhand DGP on the panel, saying he had earlier linked protests by students to "radicalisation" and "digital terrorism". Students have stayed away from most classes since Monday.

‘Highly malicious, motivated’: India rejects UN rights panel’s findings

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 26

INDIA ON Wednesday rejected a report by a UN panel that alleged discrimination against various ethnic and religious groups in the country.

The UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (UN-CERD) on Tuesday flagged concerns over human rights violations against people belonging to scheduled tribes, scheduled castes and Rohingya refugees in India.

The Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India rejects “any politically motivated highly malicious references in the report with all the contempt that it deserves”.

He said India’s commitment to combating racial discrimination “remains unwavering”. During the review, we highlighted India’s constitutional safeguards, robust legal framework, pluralism and sustained efforts to protect disadvantaged communities,” he said.

“While we will respond to the committee’s observations through the established procedure, the inter-ministerial delegation, which was led by the Solicitor General of India, Tushar Mehta, had already rejected the generalisations, unsubstantiated allegations, or tendency to exceed the Convention’s mandate during the review meeting,” Jaiswal added.

The UN human rights panel had raised concerns about violations against marginalised communities in India, and urged New Delhi to protect them from alleged abuse, torture, extrajudicial killings, and stripping of citizenship.

It also sharply criticised the implementation of the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in Assam, and raised concerns about the subjecting of Bengali-speaking Muslims to “systematic and structural racial discrimination”.

It had called for India to suspend the NRC and review its legislative framework.

India & UK to ink pact, develop propulsion systems for Navy

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, August 26

INDIA AND the UK are “very soon” poised to sign an Inter-Governmental Agreement (IGA) aimed at developing maritime electric propulsion systems for four Landing Platform Docks (LPDs) for the Indian Navy, British officials said Wednesday.

They also indicated that a second inter-governmental agreement between the countries is set to be inked soon for the procurement of British Lightweight Multirole Missiles (LMMs) for the Indian Army.

Responding to a question from The Indian Express, a top British official said an IGA for the maritime electric propulsion system for four LPDs will be signed “very shortly”.

As part of the collaboration, GE Vernova and Bharat Heavy Electricals Ltd will establish India’s first maritime Land-Based Testing Facility to support the

development of the Integrated Full Electric Propulsion (IFEP) system.

Indian warships at present do not have electric propulsion systems. They are currently powered by diesel engines, gas turbines or steam turbines. The Queen Elizabeth-class aircraft carriers of the UK Royal Navy are integrated full electric propulsion vessels.

The electric propulsion capability is meant to power bigger warships of the Indian Navy, with a displacement of over 6,000 tonnes and will be first tested on Landing Platform Docks.

A joint statement issued by both countries in November last year highlighted the intent to finalise the IGA for maritime electric propulsion systems.

The official quoted above said that negotiations and working groups have been ongoing and have been productive, adding that both sides have also been in talks over In-

A second agreement between the two will see the procurement of British Lightweight Multirole Missiles for the Indian Army

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dia’s naval fleet modernisation programme, which will also include retrofitting of certain legacy ships with electric propulsion systems, aside from looking at other modern warships of the Indian Navy.

A Statement of Intent (SoI) on Cooperation on Design and Development of Electric Propulsion Systems for the Indian Navy was signed by India and the UK in Portsmouth on 28 November, 2024, during the third meeting of the Joint Working Group on Electric Propulsion Capability Partnership.

A government statement at the time mentioned that the SoI provided a framework for cooperation in the co-design, co-creation and co-production of electric-propulsion capabil-

ities for future Indian vessels.

On the deal for LMMs, British officials said hundreds are set to be procured by India — as compared to October, when both sides had signed a 350-million-pound (\$468 million) contract to supply the Indian Army with the missiles.

The announcement was made during former British Prime Minister Keir Starmer’s India visit.

The India-UK joint statement, issued in October 2025, stated that both sides have agreed to proceed via the government-to-government route on an initial supply of LMM systems. “This will further support India’s air defence capabilities and, in the spirit of Atmanirbhar Bharat, meet the current

and future requirements of the Indian Ministry of Defence, and support a long-term collaboration on complex weapons between the two countries,” it had stated.

According to Thales UK, the LMMs are equipped with a triple-effect warhead and proximity fuse, and thus respond to various threats like light-armoured, wheeled and tracked vehicles or aerial platforms.

The missiles weigh 13kg, have an range of over 6 km and a velocity of Mach 1.5.

They can address various surface threats, from vehicles to static installations and provide surface-to-air capability targeting UAS and helicopters. It can provide very fast re-engagement and fire-on-the-move capability, and is available on shoulder launch, tripod and vehicle configurations, Thales stated.

The signing of the order will make India one of the largest customers of the missile.

UP night safari project needs fresh appraisal, SC panel told

Nikhil Ghanekar

New Delhi, August 26

THE SUPREME Court's Central Empowered Committee (CEC) has been urged to halt work on the proposed Kukrail Night Safari and Zoological Park in Lucknow—billed as India's first urban night safari project—arguing that the changes it directed in the original proposal require fresh appraisal.

The representation argued that even as Supreme Court allowed the project to proceed on July 15, changes made to the original proposal mean the environmental clearance and zoo-related approvals may not stand.

The court's go-ahead for the project was based on the CEC's recommendations, which had rejected a proposal to shift Lucknow's Nawab Wajid Ali Shah Zoological Park, setting up of an adventure park, and widen a road into four lanes.

"In light of the conditions imposed by this committee, it is submitted that the Kukrail Night Safari and Day Zoo project as proposed by the State of Uttar Pradesh can no longer be developed," former Indian Forest Service officer Prakriti Srivastava said in a representation made to the court's Central Empowered Committee (CEC) on August 21.

Srivastava is one of the peti-

“The CZA has approved our master layout plan of 850 acres, and if there are changes, we will approach CZA again... Facts and details regarding the project were placed before the Supreme Court as a matter of record, and we will comply with all conditions,” said Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Ram Kumar

tioners in a case under which the UP government sought permission for the project from the SC. While clearing the project, the SC had allowed parties to submit suggestions regarding implementation of CEC conditions. It has been argued that the Central Zoo Authority's (CZA) approval and environmental clearance were granted to the composite project, which involved moving Lucknow zoo.

The representation stated that Uttar Pradesh has to therefore prepare a new project pro-

posal and get approvals from the CZA and environmental clearance from Centre. "Until and unless these fresh proposals are obtained, the project cannot be permitted to proceed," it added.

Strivastava also sought a personal hearing with the CEC to explain the issue. One of the key issues flagged to the CEC was the project area as mentioned in the detailed project report and approved by the CZA and the changes made to it.

It was argued that the project area now is 855.07 acres, whereas the detailed project report (DPR) cites an area of 390.75 acres. "Therefore, the DPR needs a re-look and any approval based on the 'outdated' DPR has to be set aside," it said.

Citing conditions laid down in the environmental clearance granted for the project, the representation argued that the safari project required a forest clearance before work starts.

The project is situated on reserved forest land. The representation stated that the project also involves constructing an auditorium, 7D theatre, and amphitheatre, all permanent structures on forest land.

When contacted, CEC Chairperson Chandra Prakash Goyal told *The Indian Express*, "We will seek comments from the concerned departments."

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Additional Principal Chief Conservator of Forests Ram Kumar, who is also the project's director, said, "The CZA has approved our master layout plan of 850 acres, and if there are changes, we will approach CZA again. As on date, as per the amended Forest Conservation Act, 2002, zoos and safaris are considered forestry activity. Facts and details regarding the project were placed before the Supreme Court as a matter of record, and we will comply with all conditions."

The SC approval followed the UP government approaching it after an earlier order prohibited setting up zoos or safaris in forest areas without its permission.

The large batch of petitions, in which Srivastava is a co-petitioner, also challenge the Centre's amendments to the Forest Conservation Act designating safaris as a forestry activity.

The Kukrail project, estimated to cost Rs 1,510.57 crore, is proposed over an area of 855.07 acres in the northeastern part of Lucknow in the Kukrail forest.

The first phase will include a night safari, and the second phase will include a day zoo. It also includes ecotourism plans.

The CZA and the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority approved proposal.

National tribal commission seeks report from J&K govt on girl's rape, fatal pregnancy

Arun Sharma

Jammu, August 26

THE NATIONAL Commission for Scheduled Tribes (NCST) has given the Jammu and Kashmir administration five days to submit a report on the alleged sexual assault of a tribal teenager by her headmaster in J&K's Kishtwar district, leading to a fatal pregnancy.

In its notice to the administration on August 25, the commission said it was invoking its powers under Article 338A of the Indian Constitution and asked the J&K chief secretary, the director general of police and the SSP of Kishtwar to respond within that period.

The notice came after a complaint from Kabir Ahmed, member trustee of the Tribal Gujjar Bakerwal Welfare Foundation, Dhanyote. The minor had allegedly been abused by the headmaster for several months, leading to her death on August 20 after a failed abortion attempt last week. The death led to protests across the district.

The headmaster and his brother — both of whom are said to have accompanied the teenager for the failed abortion attempt — have been arrested. The education department has initiated an enquiry and suspended the headmaster.

The scheduled tribes commission said the police had failed to invoke the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act even though the teenager was a tribal. The commission has also asked authorities to verify the status of the girl and the headmaster, provide protection to the family, consider compensation for them, and preserve evidence.

The case emerged after the girl complained of stomach pain and was allegedly taken to the local health centre, which confirmed her pregnancy. She was then taken to local medical facilities, where a fatal abortion attempt allegedly weakened her.

Labour was allegedly induced, leading to a stillbirth.

The girl died on her way to a hospital near Udhampur.



Behind Israel’s West Bank push, an October story



P R KUMARASWAMY

HEAD OF the October 27 Knesset election, it appears that Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu will go to any lengths to return to office. The controversy over building 1,200 housing units in E-1 is just the latest example. East 1, or E-1 for short, is a small piece of territory, about 12 square kilometres, in the West Bank. It is part of the municipal limits of the settlement of Ma’ale Adumim and lies east of East Jerusalem. Ma’ale Adumim was established as a settlement in 1975, when Yitzhak Rabin was prime minister, and was upgraded to city status in 1991. With close to 35,000 Israeli citizens (2015 figures), it is one of the largest Israeli settlements in the occupied territories.

Since the Oslo Accords of 1993, there have been plans to connect Ma’ale Adumim to Jerusalem’s municipal boundaries. The purpose was twofold: To provide territorial continuity between the two and to expand and consolidate Jerusalem’s demographic and strategic security.

Under the Taba Agreement of September 1995 (signed just weeks before Rabin’s assassination), the E-1 enclave was part of Area C, where Israel has complete security control. The area is largely uninhabited and covers

about 12,000 dunums, or about 12 square kilometres. Since January 1994, weeks after the signing of the Declaration of Principles with Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat, various Israeli governments have toyed with the idea of establishing a settlement in E-1. Under the Clinton Parameters of December 2000, E-1 was supposed to be part of a swap deal in which Israel would annex Ma’ale Adumim, including E-1, in return for withdrawing from 94-96 per cent of the West Bank. To curb Israeli efforts, the Palestinians have been building individual housing units in the area, which Israel periodically demolishes. Israel’s prolonged reluctance to pursue new settlement activity has largely been shaped by American and international criticism.

The latest effort comes amid the forthcoming election. While Likud, led by Netanyahu, still leads the opinion polls, several surveys indicate a dip in the party’s seat count. From 32 seats in 2022, pollsters predict a range of 20 to 32 seats, with most forecasting seats in the 20s. Centre-right and right-wing parties appear to be the main gainers at Netanyahu’s expense. According to observers, Itamar Ben-Gvir, the leader of the ultranationalist and pronouncedly anti-Arab Otzma Yehudit (Jewish Power) party, is the real challenger to Netanyahu. As the minister of national security and a member of the security cabinet, Ben-Gvir has been a key factor in Netanyahu’s hardline security stance since October 7.

While Israel’s response to Hamas, Hezbollah, and the Islamic

Republic of Iran has delivered tangible short-term military gains, Netanyahu is struggling to translate them into political gains. Israel is more secure today than in October 2023. The disarmament of Hamas and Hezbollah has become a precondition for peace, stability, and the reconstruction of the Gaza Strip and Lebanon, respectively. Except for Iran, no major power endorses, let alone contributes to, the survival and strengthening of the “Axis of Resistance”. Under President Ahmed al-Sharaa, Syria is no longer the conduit for Iranian arms supplies to the Shia militant groups in Lebanon.

Yet, if the opinion polls are any indication, the military “victory” is proving insufficient to win more votes for the Likud. Within the party, Netanyahu has established unchallengeable authority over seat allocations. Out of the top 30 seats, he managed to reserve 11 for candidates considered loyal to him. This pushed several other Likud figures to the margins, with no real chance of entering the Knesset.

However, securing broader endorsement of his leadership among the Israeli population is more challenging. A considerable segment of the population has not forgotten his role, or lack thereof, in the October 7 terror attack. Several senior military and security figures admitted responsibility and resigned. This has not been the case for the political leadership. PM Netanyahu has not taken any direct personal responsibility for Israel’s 9/11 moment. True to his style, he has shifted the blame and has not

gone beyond saying that “everyone, from the top to the bottom, shares responsibility”.

Above all, Netanyahu and his cabinet have consistently resisted public calls for a national inquiry commission headed by the sitting president of the Supreme Court (equivalent to the Chief Justice of India). In the past, Israel had two such commissions, led by Shimon Agranat (over the Yom Kippur War of 1973) and Yitzhak Kahan (over the Sabra and Shatila massacre of 1982). Under Israeli law, everyone, including the prime minister, would have to testify under oath and could be cross-examined. So far, Netanyahu has been dodging this. However, should he feel it necessary, he might reverse course and make it an electoral promise.

The new settlement construction in E-1 is part of Netanyahu’s efforts to shore up support for his political alliance. A victory of the right-religious coalition is essential to Netanyahu’s political future. Losing a few seats to the far right is preferable to handing them to the centre-left Opposition. One should view Netanyahu’s reluctance to endorse and embrace the American disarmament plans for the Gaza Strip in this context. Appearing weak or submitting to US President Donald Trump’s diktats will cost him more votes than a defiant posture. Thus, despite the near-unanimous Arab-European chorus against his E-1 plans, Netanyahu is driven more by electoral calculations on an issue that has remained dormant for over three decades.

The writer teaches contemporary Middle East at Jawaharlal Nehru University

A death at IIT-Delhi, many invisible struggles

BY ALL accounts, Rishikesh Kumar from Bihar was a bright young man who had made it to IIT-Delhi in pursuit of a dream. Physics fascinated him; poetry offered another outlet for his creativity. Yet beneath the promise and ambition was a young man struggling with mental-health challenges. His death, allegedly by suicide on August 22, has once again brought into focus the helplessness that can lurk beneath the surface of hyper-competitive institutions. Kumar’s death was the eighth such incident at the campus since 2023.

Over the last five years, the IITs have been proactive in acknowledging that access does not always translate into comfort and belonging. Measures such as supernumerary quotas for women and athletes in undergraduate courses to enhance diversity, and the creation of posts such as the dean of student well-being, recognise that the pressures within elite campuses are shaped as much by the collision between identity and expectation as by an intensely competitive environment. The pressure does not end with securing a place at an IIT; for many, it simply changes form — from the struggle to get in, to the struggle to keep up and fit in. A 2023-24 IIT-Delhi committee described a culture of post-coaching burnout, and alienation among marginalised and first-generation students. It makes every setback — from a failed relationship to an inadequate score — feel unusually consequential.

Following protests, IIT-Delhi has set up a committee to conduct a probe into Kumar’s death. But the questions go beyond the campus. Far too often, mental health is looked at through the prism of individual histories. But for young people who have demonstrated remarkable fortitude in coping with pressures along their journey to some of the country’s premier institutions, what explains their inability to deal with what follows? It is this contradiction that parents and educators must address with urgency. How can environments be built where ambition and well-being go hand in hand, where counselling creates safe spaces, where empathy shows youngsters how to regulate their response to life’s vagaries? The road ahead must involve a rethinking of the culture of competition itself, so that institutions do not merely produce high achievers, but are home to thriving young people.



PURVI MEHTA

SEVERAL REPORTS earlier this month noted a nearly 50 per cent drop in employment generated under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin), or the VB-GRAM-G. The scheme, launched last year as a successor to the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme, guarantees 125 days of rural wage employment, faster payments, and a technology-enabled delivery system built for a Viksit Bharat. It is the world’s largest public-works programme, backed by a budget of Rs 95,692 crore.

The initial dip is too early to judge the scheme’s efficacy. The low numbers do pose a more important question, however: Is a wage-guarantee model, however well designed, the right instrument for rural India in 2026? Public employment guarantees have a long lineage, from Depression-era America to emperors who commissioned public works, including temples, to generate wages. The logic was straightforward: When private employment cannot absorb surplus labour — because industry is nascent, services are thin, and agriculture is overcrowded — the state must step in as an employer, providing wages through public works to prevent destitution. That logic held force in India when manufacturing was underdeveloped, and the services boom was an urban phenomenon. For rural households, a guaranteed unskilled wage job was often the only buffer between subsistence and distress.

But the India of 2026 is seeing sustained industrial expansion and a rapidly diversifying rural non-farm sector, and has a digital economy that has reached deeper into villages than most of us appreciate. Rural users now account for the majority of the country’s roughly 950 million active internet users. That connectivity has translated into consumption. Rural FMCG demand, for example, has been growing at roughly four times the rate of urban demand and is projected to reach \$220 billion, a nearly tenfold rise from a decade ago. India’s rural markets are no longer passive recipients of government programmes.

Nearly 64 per cent of India’s population and roughly two-thirds of its 378 million young people live in rural areas. Wages create livelihoods, not careers. The rural youth today are more educated, more connected,

and more exposed to opportunity than any previous generation, but they are also less willing to queue for 125 days of manual wage labour on public works when better alternatives exist or could exist, especially closer to home. This arguably could be the real story behind VB-G RAM-G’s disappointing opening month.

The question is no longer how to guarantee more days of wage labour, but how to create genuine, durable employment in sectors that already sit close to rural India’s comparative advantage. Sectors that convert local resources, local produce and local labour into local livelihoods while leveraging on the increasing global connectivity.

Food processing is one example. The sector is projected to nearly double from its current size by 2030, built substantially on raw materials that rural India produces — milk, fruit, grain, spices. Renewable energy offers another example: India’s clean-energy targets could generate over 44 lakh jobs by 2030, with local, decentralised and labour-intensive production. Strengthening the ecosystem of rural manufacturing and service industries — not necessarily giant factories, but clusters of SMEs producing textiles, farm equipment, healthcare devices, renewable-energy components, construction materials and consumer goods — offers the kind of localised but large-scale rural employment a public-works scheme tries and often fails. Rural healthcare, agri-logistics, and small-scale manufacturing round out a portfolio of sectors where demand, resources and workforce already co-exist in rural India. Capital, skilling, and market linkages, not manual labour opportunities, are what Viksit Bharat demands.

This is not an argument for abandoning income support for India’s most vulnerable rural households. That safety net remains necessary, but it should no longer be the principal mechanism of rural employment policy. The next iteration of India’s rural employment architecture cannot simply focus on executing the old idea better. It must revise the idea itself. Wages are a short-term transaction. They buy a household immediate relief. Jobs provide the nation with a future workforce. Viksit Bharat will outgrow its need for wages as welfare; it will demand productive jobs.

The writer is a senior agriculture industry advisor. Views are personal

The question is no longer how to guarantee more days of wage labour, but how to create genuine, durable employment in sectors that already sit close to rural India’s comparative advantage

Centre-state compromise on mines, minerals is in tatters



ROHIT CHANDRA

IN THE 1950s, B C Roy made a trip to Poland to talk to coal-mining companies about bringing their technologies to India. As Chief Minister of West Bengal in a newly independent India, he had an economic vision for his state that relied on coal-based industrialisation; his vision was somewhat divergent from the Planning Commission's goals at the time. He could afford to think this way because the coal industry had not been nationalised, state governments could still make major claims on major minerals within their boundaries, and the model of industrialisation during that era relied on these natural resources.

No chief minister in India can have similar ambitions today. The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957 (MMDR) and its amendments have progressively dispossessed state governments of the right to exploit major minerals within their boundaries. These rights now lie with the Union government, but in return there has been an uneasy federal compromise around minerals for the last half-century: The Union would allocate mining rights for major minerals, states would be allowed to tax these minerals or the underlying land at some kind of periodically renegotiated rate.

With the recent passing of the MMDR Amendment Act, 2026 in both houses of Parliament, any vestiges of this compromise are lost now; it gives the central government control over all mineral and mineral land taxation. Effectively, it is a declaration of war on fiscal federalism writ large, and a potentially unconstitutional evasion of the 2024 Supreme Court ruling around states' rights over mineral taxation. The Act turns what was once a fiscal right of states into a discretionary allocation that can be altered by central rules at any point. For states with large mining economies, this could affect anywhere between 10 and 20 per cent of their annual revenues. Ironically, the states most affected by this at the moment are currently politically aligned with the Union; one wonders how state finance ministers feel about this potential cut to their budgets.

Many MPs had asked for the Bill to be referred to a standing committee. Instead, the MMDR amendments have become the latest case of fiscal myopia and corporate lobbying short-circuiting necessary parliamentary deliberation. Despite its fiscal implications over the coming years, it was discussed for a princely total of five minutes in the Lok Sabha and 40 minutes in the Rajya Sabha. Given mounting dissatisfaction with the law, the Union government has now deployed bureaucrats and technocrats (instead of politicians) to defend it.

Perhaps there is an imaginary world where state governments are the entire problem, that ease of doing business is hobbled by them only, that the kleptocracy and fiscal profligacy of the periphery can only be reined in by the righteous fiscal discipline of the core. That certainly seems to be the current narrative. However, this does not explain why after having Union government control over multiple states, sometimes for decades, mining still evades ease of doing business.

Part of the answer to this lies in how localised mining, its impacts and its induced economies are. Because of the density of approvals, regulations and negotiations, only a few large companies in India have been able to navigate the ecosystem at scale. Mining is both essential to industrial and energy policy in India and socially and environmentally devastating. It requires delicate negotiation and repeated interaction for local communities and politicians to have any faith in mining companies; our public-sector mining companies have been much better at this than private miners. Mining should never be too easy; companies need to earn the social and political right to mine, not simply pay for a licence or lease and proceed how they want.

As this law manifests the unending fiscal hunger of the Union government, there's a lesson to be learned from how China managed its fiscal transition. In 1994, Beijing dramatically centralised its fiscal management by keeping a much larger share of overall taxes. However, it opened an escape valve by trusting provinces to financially innovate through other instruments; this included direct, unmediated access to capital markets. Such policy was crucial to the development of regional models of growth in China's provinces. India has kept all of these escape valves closed for now and its fiscal policies are steadily increasing pressures on states. Perhaps it's time to open them before overbearing fiscal dominance causes an explosion. Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1

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AAKASH JOSHI

IS GURUGRAM worth living in? Or, for that matter, is a fancy apartment in Koramangala or a gated colony in South Delhi? For much of the time, most of the year, those who have done well enough — thanks to circumstances, inheritance, luck and, of course, hard work — to buy their way out of the tribulations that the majority of Indians suffer through don't even really ask the question. We can go from an air-conditioned private vehicle — Ubers and Olas included — to an air-conditioned office, looking at the heat, sun and those who live on the street through tinted sunglasses. Our children do not need much from the state — their school

One-day breach in the island of privilege

is private, their care and that of the home often outsourced, wholly or in substantial measure, to the "help". Healthcare can be afforded and availed in private hospitals that rival hotels in their swankiness.

Lives of luxury that would be unfathomable to most of our counterparts in the West, made possible by being well off in a poor country. We complain, of course, but deep down, we are bound to realise that for all the whingeing about bad roads and poor systems, life isn't all that bad. Sometimes, though, this island of privilege is breached, if even for a few hours or a day or two at most.

The harrowing tale of Siddharth Kasid, reported in this newspaper, will resonate with many. The 39-year-old resident of Uniworld Gardens, Gurugram, who works at an investment bank, was forced to wade through waist deep water to rescue his

daughter and other children stranded on the highway. Their school bus, among several others carrying children as young as four and five years old, was not moving for hours — thanks to the flooded roads that are a consequence of Gurugram's poor civic infrastructure. Kasid summed up his ordeal with the following conclusion: "Gurgaon is simply not worth living in anymore. We don't want to live here. My family goes

For the many who live on the roads that are now flooded, traverse them in public buses, and walk the terrible footpaths, the monsoon havoc is just a different degree of what they face every day

through this hell every single year despite the high taxes we pay to the government and the hefty rents. We are now seriously mulling moving out of Gurgaon once this academic session ends."

The parent's anger is understandable. Like so many of us, he faced the brutality of life in India not as routine but as a rupture. He was shocked at the fact that "in my professional life, I manage a team of 45 people, and we make sure there is basic courtesy and communication; here, the authorities showed none". How many of us, though, treat everyone in our lives with the same dignity that we expect? How many of the colonies in Gurugram, Noida and all over the country have "service lifts" for workers whose collars aren't white?

His colony, like many others, is green, well-constructed and has many amenities

within its gates. But sewage and stormwater drains, roads and public infrastructure are not private goods. For the many who live on the roads that are now flooded, traverse them in public buses (even the Metro is sometimes too expensive for working people in NCR) and shared rickshaws, and walk the terrible footpaths, the monsoon havoc is just a different degree of what they face every day. Their children, too, are stuck in more ways than one.

None of this is to say that the government should not provide basic infrastructure or not be held accountable. For that, though, people with a voice and privilege will have to stop walling themselves off. Or just move because we can afford to.

The writer is associate editor, The Indian Express. akash.joshi@expressindia.com

NPCIL vertical to help deploy indigenous heavy water technology

“The cost of foreign technologies can be viable in India only with bulk purchases. But that is difficult at this stage as

• GEOPOLITICS

Strikes to sanctions: The limits of US moves on Iran



EXPERT EXPLAINS

BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH, DELHI

ON MONDAY, the US threatened to impose severe sanctions on any country or entity that maintains economic ties with Iran.

US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, who announced 'Operation Economic Out-cast', termed it "Economic D-Day", a reference to the June 1944 Allied offensive against Nazi-occupied France.

The US has issued fresh sanctions against Iran's digital assets, technology, gold, aviation and shipping sectors, with the Office of Foreign Assets Control sanctioning "nearly 60 entities, individuals, and vessels in multiple jurisdictions that enable the Iranian regime's recklessness". These include sanctions against firms across countries such as China, UK, France, Singapore, UAE and Ukraine.

In the hours following the announcement, Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces, Asim Munir, made his second trip to Tehran since the March war. Islamabad described the visit as part of its efforts to "promote regional peace and stability". *Al Arabiya* also reported that Munir spoke to US President Donald Trump in the lead-up to the visit.

These interlinked developments come at a time when the US appears to be shifting away from its military strategy that has failed to dislodge the Iranian regime. Both countries are entering a *de facto* ceasefire following the expiry of the interim peace framework's 60-day implementation period. What do these developments mean for any future US-Iran negotiations?

D-Day sanctions

The US's new 'Economic D-Day' sanctions are only the latest in a series of sanctions regimes that Washington has had in place against Iran since 1979, the year of the revolution. President Trump intensified these sanctions through his "maximum pressure" campaign in his first term (2017-2021). While the Joe Biden administration diluted this campaign's measures, the second Trump administration renewed them

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• IRANIAN CURRENCY IN FREEFALL

One US dollar now costs 2 million rials in Iran.



in February 2025.

This meant that by the time the US attacked Iran a year later, the Iranian economy was reeling from inflation crossing 50% (near hyperinflation), national per capita income dropping to about \$5,000, rising youth unemployment and the rial in near free-fall. The currency has now fallen to around 2 million rial per US dollar.

Hence, despite the US's aggressive framing of these sanctions, they only represent the intensification of its historic economic outlook towards Iran.

On August 25, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio reportedly said Washington was pivoting from strikes to sanctions, indicating an apparent US disinclination for resuming military action. This comes even as Iran continues to strike tankers passing through the US-backed southern channel near Oman in the Strait of Hormuz.

Limited effects of sanctions

Historically, US sanctions on Iran have proven to have limited deterrence effect. Despite their adverse economic effect, the principal affected party is the citizenry of Iran with government actors consolidating power further as the sole arbiter of resources.

It was the George Bush administration that shifted from blanket sanctions to targeted financial and sectoral ones in 2005 and 2006. President Barack Obama expanded and intensified this targeted approach through the Comprehensive Iran Sanctions, Accountability, and Divestment Act in 2010.

Trump, however, triggered a reversal



A market in Tehran's Grand Bazaar. AP

through the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act sanctions regime in his first term.

Now, the imposition of the D-Day sanctions reflects the limits of military means as an effective coercion instrument against the Islamic republic. But they also represent a large-scale unlearning of Washington's lessons from its history of economic coercion against Tehran. Iran has near-continually been the most heavily sanctioned country in this century. Its sustained ability to both prevent regime collapse as well as to militarily respond to American attacks successfully in 2026 have already proved the ineffectiveness of Washington's historic economic measures.

Tehran's popularisation of a "resistance economy" has meant that the current Iranian generation has been forced to largely normalise living conditions under external economic duress (supplemented by internal corruption).

While this has indeed meant frequent popular pressure on the regime through demonstrations, the current war-time conditions and mood of national solidarity mean that the Trump administration's nationwide economic targeting will only harden Tehran's resolve. Arguably, such conditions can also help the Iranian government find greater public acceptance for increased austerity measures to absorb the impact of the new sanctions.

It is worth remembering that the new American sanctions are not occurring in a pre-February 2026 reality — when the regime did have any organic trigger for na-

War and peace

The US has issued fresh sanctions against Iran's digital assets, technology, gold, aviation and shipping.

Meanwhile, Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces, Asim Munir, made his second trip to Tehran since the March war as part of efforts to 'promote regional peace'.

Amid signs of Pakistani mediation, the US seems to be adopting an economic strategy against Iran. But this may do little to improve its bargaining position

tional solidarity, was reeling from the effects of the December-January anti-governments demonstrations and was negotiating with the US for nuclear concessions in exchange for relief from existing sanctions.

Rather, Iran's solidified control over the Strait of Hormuz following the US-Israeli war has left it with economic leverage to meet economic coercion. It is arguably the adverse impact on energy shipping through the narrow waterway that was was among the prominent triggers for the pivot Rubio referred to.

Renewal of mediation?

For Iran, the D-Day sanctions do not represent any new US posture, apart from Washington's reduced appetite for military exchanges. Rather, it hardens Iran's learning that escalation is the only way to deal with Washington's attempts to undermine its bargaining power.

Indeed, Tehran's escalatory actions since the war began — from strikes on Gulf countries to attacks on shipping, especially vessels following the US-approved route — have improved Iran's bargaining position in negotiations for a final deal.

For Washington, the new economic measures (despite their effects being old) allow the Trump administration to project strength and cushion its potential return to negotiations with Tehran after military failure. Iran itself specifically requires the US to return to the framework and uphold Article 5 — which provides for joint Omani-Iranian administration of Hormuz). This was among Iran's demands from the US, conveyed through Munir, as reported by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps-affiliated *Tasnim News*.

In any case, Iran and Oman are continuing to discuss Article 5's implementation. On Tuesday, the Omani Foreign Minister asserted that both sides expected to announce a joint temporary transit corridor through the Strait of Hormuz and joint mine clearing operations soon. US President claimed on the same day that the strait had been cleared of all mines. On Wednesday, Iran and Oman reached agreements on their share of Hormuz and revenues.

Iran will feel the need to continue proving its readiness for continued fighting (at least until the US mid-term elections in November), alongside indirect negotiations with the US through Pakistan. Ultimately, while D-Day sanctions or fresh US strikes on Iran might trigger a resumption of war, both sides remain focused on bettering their bargaining positions.

• HEALTH

How AI can help target protein that contributes to pancreatic cancer

Arnav Chandrasekhar

Bengaluru, August 26

RENOWNED US-BASED medical centre Mayo Clinic recently announced that it has co-developed a cancer treatment with Bengaluru-based artificial intelligence (AI) startup Sravathi AI Technology, under an intellectual property sharing arrangement. This treatment targets a specific protein called GIP1 that, in certain circumstances, can contribute to the growth of many different types of cancer, including pancreatic cancer — one of the deadliest forms of cancer. The findings were published in the scientific journal *Cell Reports*.

A difficult target

GIP1 does not cause cancer on its own. Experts from Sravathi AI said when there is a problem in the expression or signalling of this protein in the body, then cancer cells can use the "pathways" associated with this protein to grow excessively or invade other parts of the body.

Pancreatic ductal adenocarcinoma (PDAC) — the most common type of exocrine pancreatic cancer — remains highly aggressive, with a five-year survival rate under 13.3% owing to late diagnosis, rapid progression, and therapeutic resistance. GIP1, which is overproduced in PDAC, drives tumour growth and resistance to chemotherapy but has remained "undruggable" due to its PDZ domain.

The PDZ domain is made up of amino acids (also the building blocks of proteins) and is found in the signalling proteins of bacteria, yeast, plants, viruses, and animals.

On why this protein is so hard to target during treatment, Sravathi CEO Parag Tipnis told *The Indian Express*: "Its PDZ domain interacts with multiple proteins through broad, shallow surfaces, making it difficult for conventional small molecules to bind effectively. It is also a signalling hub, so blocking one pathway may not be enough to stop the others that remain active."

DEADLY DISEASE

● Pancreatic ductal adenocarcinoma is the most common and aggressive type of exocrine pancreatic cancer.

● It has a five-year survival rate under 13.3% owing to late diagnosis, rapid progression, and therapeutic resistance.

The treatment

Using advanced computational modeling, machine learning, and predictive analytics, a selective and specific small molecule inhibitor of GIP1 was identified, targeting its PDZ domain. This molecule inhibitor is called GIP1i.

Sravathi's founder Gurram Kishan told *The Indian Express*: "We started with around 40,000 molecules and progressively narrowed them down to five candidates, of which two were synthesised and tested. Generative AI helped us design the initial molecules, while predictive AI was used to assess properties such as toxicity and absorption." "We then used molecular modelling and quantum chemistry to identify the molecules most likely to bind GIP1, ultimately leading us to the final candidate," Kishan added.

Timeline for human use

Sravathi AI began work on discovering the molecule in 2023, completing their research in about five months. The Mayo Clinic then continued its research, which included animal trials. According to Kishan, if the treatment turns out to be suitable for human use, it could be in use after about three years.

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• GLOBAL

\$100,000 fee for H-1B: The new legal route Trump is pursuing

Soumyarendra Barik

New Delhi, August 26

BARELY TWO months after a US court struck down a \$100,000 charge on new H-1B visa petitions, the Donald Trump-led US administration is trying to impose it again. This time, through a formal rulemaking process and under a different provision of immigration law.

The Department of Homeland Security (DHS) has proposed an additional \$103,265 fee on every H-1B petition subject to the annual visa cap. The amount would be paid by the sponsoring employer at the time of filing, on top of existing H-1B fees. The proposal is not yet in force — after seeking public comments for 30 days, the DHS would have to issue a final rule. US Vice President JD Vance has backed the move.

Indians, who are the biggest beneficiaries of the visa programme, stand to lose the most if the proposal goes through.

The proposal

The H-1B programme allows US employers to hire foreign workers in "specialty occupations", typically jobs requiring at least

a bachelor's degree. The US Congress caps new H-1Bs at 65,000 a year, with another 20,000 available to people with a master's or higher degree from a US university.

The new \$103,265 charge would apply to these cap-subject petitions, including the advanced-degree category. It would not apply to cap-exempt H-1B petitions, including many filed by universities, non-profit research institutions, and government research organisations.

DHS estimates the fee would raise about \$8.8 billion annually, assuming 85,000 fee-paying petitions. Unlike a normal visa processing charge, the money is meant to support costs across the wider immigration system.

The proposal also makes clear that the policy has a labour-market objective. DHS says a six-figure charge would make employers less likely to choose an H-1B worker over a qualified American unless they genuinely need the foreign worker's specialised skills.

Why earlier fee was scrapped

Trump had imposed the earlier charge through a September 2025 presidential di-

Under lens

● Critics question whether the H-1B programme is being used for its original purpose — allowing companies to fill specialised jobs for which sufficiently skilled American workers are unavailable — or as a route to access cheaper foreign labour.

● The Trump administration argues that some companies, particularly in tech, have continued to hire H-1B workers even while laying off American staffers.

rective, relying on provisions of the Immigration and Nationality Act that allow the president to restrict the entry of foreigners deemed detrimental to US interests.

This June, a US federal court ruled that the \$100,000 payment functioned as a tax, not merely an entry restriction. Since the Constitution gives Congress the power to levy taxes, the court held that the immigration provisions cited by Trump did not clearly authorise the President to impose such a charge. Upon appeal, the First Circuit Court of Appeals in July refused to pause the lower court's order.

The biggest difference in the new approach is the legal route. Instead of relying primarily on presidential authority to restrict entry, DHS is invoking its statutory power under Section 286 of the Immigration and Nationality Act to set fees that recover the costs of immigration adjudication and naturalisation services. It is also going through notice-and-comment rulemaking rather than imposing the fee directly by proclamation.

That does not necessarily insulate the policy from another lawsuit, however. DHS itself acknowledges that it has not histori-

cally charged one narrow class of immigration applicants to fund such broad costs across multiple agencies, including programmes with which H-1B employers may have no direct connection.

Impact on Indian workers

US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS) data show that people born in India accounted for 71% of all approved H-1B petitions in FY2024. People born in China come a distant second, hovering at the 12-13% mark since 2018.

Between October 2022 and September 2023, 72% of the nearly 4 lakh H-1B visas issued went to Indian nationals. During the same period, top four Indian IT majors with a presence in the US — Infosys, TCS, HCL, and Wipro — got approval for around 20,000 employees to work on the H-1B visa, as per USCIS data.

Industry body Nasscom has urged Washington to weigh the programme's role in filling short-term skills gaps, while pointing out that Indian technology companies have expanded local hiring in the US and reduced their dependence on H-1B workers.

• LEGAL

OBC creamy layer: Why govt wants clarity from top court on 'rules of the game'

Amaal Sheikh

New Delhi, August 26

THE SUPREME COURT Tuesday agreed to constitute a Special Bench to hear the Centre's plea seeking clarification on whether its March 2026 verdict on OBC creamy layer criteria applies to the Civil Services Examination (CSE) 2025, whose results were announced five days before the judgment. The dispute focuses on what happens when a court changes the legal position after an examination process has largely concluded.

The case

The case originated from a Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) letter of October 14, 2004, clarifying an Official Memorandum (OM) of September 1993 on the creamy layer criterion for OBCs. The creamy layer refers to the economically, socially, and educationally advanced members of the OBC category who are excluded from gov-

ernment reservation benefits.

The 1993 OM had excluded income from salary and agricultural sources from the income/wealth test used to determine creamy layer status. The 2004 clarification, however, said the salary income of employees in PSUs and the private sector would be a criterion. This, however, began to be applied rigorously only from CSE-2015.

Since then, around 100 candidates who possessed caste certificates issued by competent authorities and cleared the CSE have found their OBC claims rejected by the DoPT on the creamy layer ground. Most of them are parties in different petitions before the SC and various High Courts. The petitioners argue that this was "hostile discrimination" between the wards of government servants and those of PSUs or private sector employees.

In its judgment on March 11, 2026, the SC ruled that income cannot be the sole criterion for determining the creamy layer among OBCs. The top court had set a six-

month timeline (until September 11) for implementation of its verdict, which the Centre had appeared set to enforce until its plea on Tuesday.

If the judgment is implemented in full, its benefits would extend not only to candidates appearing in future examinations but also to those affected in earlier cycles. It could hence lead to revised ranks for some.

'Rules of the game'

One of the settled principles in service law is that the criteria governing a selection process cannot be changed midway through the process. The Supreme Court has described this as the "rules of the game" doctrine.

A Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in Tej Prakash Pathak v. Rajasthan High Court (2024) held that "the rules of the game, meaning thereby, that the criteria for selection cannot be altered by the authorities concerned in the middle or after the process of selection has commenced".

The principle exists to protect candidates who enter a recruitment or admission process based on a particular set of rules. Once the process begins, courts have generally been reluctant to let authorities introduce new criteria or change existing ones midway.

Recent NEET matter

In January 2026, the Supreme Court applied the same principle to an admissions dispute in Divyot Sekhon v. State of Punjab. The case concerned admissions to MBBS and BDS courses under Punjab's sports quota. After the prospectus had been issued and candidates had applied, the state widened the eligibility criteria for the quota.

The court held that "it is well-settled that the rules of the game cannot be altered once the game has begun", adding that the principle was "just as applicable to admission processes to educational courses as it would be to recruitment processes". Having found the revised criteria un-

lawful, the court then turned to the question of relief. Ordinarily, it noted, it could have directed the entire merit list to be redrawn. However, it declined to do so, observing that such an exercise would affect candidates who were not before it and would "unsettle settled matters".

The Centre's plea

In its application before the SC, the government has argued that the March 11 judgment "altering settled position" on creamy layer criteria was delivered five days after the final result of CSE-2025 had already been declared. It has said that CSE-2025 "stood substantially concluded prior to the pronouncement of the judgment" and is presently at the "terminal stage of service allocation".

The Centre further argued that a "mechanical or unqualified application of the ratio of the said judgment, with retrospective effect, to the already-concluded selection process of CSE-2025" would create "a peculiar and acute anomaly amounting to discrimi-

nation inter se candidates of the very examination cycle sought to be benefited".

According to the government, reopening category-wise merit lists at this stage would have a cascading effect on training schedules, batch strength, cadre allocation, seniority, and pay fixation.

Those concerns resemble the considerations that pushed the court in Divyot Sekhon not to redraw an entire admission list after finding the governing rule unlawful. But in that case, the court moulded the relief in a manner that avoided disrupting students who had already secured admissions and were not before the court.

The Centre's plea has asked the court to clarify that the March 11 judgment should not be applied "with retrospective effect" to the "already-concluded selection process of CSE-2025" so as to "unsettle completed admissions in higher educational institutions, completed academic sessions, degrees already conferred, or settled rights of students".

Himalayan tsunami shatters Nepal

‘Saved by mango tree’: Survivors recount chaos as torrent sweeps away homes

Reuters

Kathmandu, August 26

NEPALI LABOURER Bibek Kumal was digging a toilet pit outside a newly built house on Wednesday when a wall of water, mud and rock came roaring down, sweeping him and everything near him away.

Kumal, 24, was working in Bidur, downstream from the worst-hit Rasuwa district, near Nepal's Himalayan border with China's Tibet, when he heard a hissing sound. His four co-workers, standing above the five-foot deep pit, shouted at him to get out and run. By the time he scrambled out of the pit, his co-workers had already fled.

"I started running. Then a wall of water came thundering down as if it was an earthquake," Kumal said from his bed at Kathmandu's National Trauma Centre, his brother Dinesh sitting beside him.

The torrent swept him downstream amid mud and debris, but "luckily I was stuck up in a mango tree", he said. "Had there been no mango tree, I'd have been washed away to death."

Three others also injured in the flood were being treated alongside Kumal, as more people were transported to the capital Kathmandu. Authorities said they rescued over 114 people who were being treated at hospitals in Kathmandu and Rasuwa.

Outside the hospital, well-wishers, friends and onlookers crowded the small compound of the trauma centre.

The flood, triggered after what appeared to be the collapse of a mass of mud and rock into a



Damaged houses stand near the swollen, debris-choked banks of the Trishuli River after flash floods in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Wednesday. PTI Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

river on the frontier between Nepal and Tibet, devastated settlements and infrastructure downstream. The exact cause of the mudslide was not clear, but the German Research Centre for Geosciences said there was a 4.4-magnitude quake about seven minutes before the time shown on the security footage time-stamp.

Survivor Kumal said as he clung to the mango tree, he watched the house where he had been working disappear.

In the hospital bed opposite him, 11-year-old Rihana Lamichhane narrowly escaped. "I was at school. They closed school because of this and asked us to go home," she said. "As I was crossing the river, suddenly flood water came gushing down."

She suffered injuries to her chest and leg but said: "I am happy to be safe. I have no idea what happened to my friends."



• WHAT TRIGGERED THE DELUGE?

WHAT HAPPENED?

Torrential floods swallowed roads, bridges, houses, and power projects in the border areas of Nepal, and triggered a mudslide that hit Gyirong Port, a major land crossing with neighbouring Tibet.

WHAT CAUSED CALAMITY?

It is suspected that an earthquake struck the region and triggered an ice-rock avalanche on the Lhende Khola river in Nepal. The river runs through both Nepal and Tibet.



ARE ANY FOREIGNERS MISSING?

Apart from many Indians, three US citizens, 12 British citizens, 8 South Koreans have been reported missing. The other missing included 17 Malaysian nationals, 4 South Africans, and one each from Australia and the Netherlands.

HAS THE DANGER PASSED?

Authorities have warned a second flood may occur since a blockage lodged upstream on the Lhende Khola river.

THE SITUATION NOW

Police and military personnel were engaged in rescue efforts, although officials have said rescue helicopters would not be able to land in the affected areas until the waters recede.

A boy looks at the devastation caused by flash floods along the Trishuli River in Nepal's Nuwakot district on Wednesday. AP

U.S. MUST ACCEPT OUR TERMS: TEHRAN

Iran & Oman still working on Strait accord; waterway remains blocked

IRGC claims two countries agreed on how to share passage, revenues

Reuters

Cairo, Dubai, August 26

IRAN AND Oman are still working on the details of an agreement on the Strait of Hormuz, a senior Iranian source said Wednesday, after Iran's Revolutionary Guards said the two countries had agreed how to share the waterway and its revenues.

The elite force's spokesperson, echoing Tehran's official stance, also said the strait would not open unless the US met Tehran's conditions under an interim ceasefire agreement that was struck in June before unravelling. Those conditions include an end to the US blockade on Iranian ports, compensation and removal of sanctions.

Most shipping has since been shut down, driving global energy prices higher, as Tehran and Washington have tried to assert control over the channel, imposing separate blockades.

"An agreement with Oman over the Strait of Hormuz has not been finalised," the senior Iranian source told *Reuters*, adding that the talks were continuing on the details of an accord.

A spokesperson for Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) said Iran and Oman had reached an agreement on their shares of the territory and revenues.

"The Strait of Hormuz be-

India and China can help resolve conflict: Hillary

New York: India and China could be among key players who could contribute to resolving the West Asia conflict if US President Donald Trump wants to use "diplomacy instead of bluster", said former Secretary of State Hillary Clinton.

Talking about the conflict, Clinton, in an interview with C-SPAN, said: "The misconceptions on a strategic level have led us to where we are."

"If you want to figure out how Trump could get out of this, I think the key to it is probably China and India, because if you look at who buys the most oil and gas from Iran, it's China and India," said Clinton. PTI

longs to Iran and the country of Oman... We have been in negotiations with Oman for about a month, and we have reached results that are acceptable to both sides," Hossein Mohebbi said.

"In these negotiations, agreements have been reached regarding the share of each country in the waters of the Strait and the share of Iran and Oman in its revenues," he added.

Following talks on Tuesday between Iran and Oman, Omani Foreign Minister Badr Albusaidi said he was "hopeful that we will soon announce a temporary corridor for the Strait of Hormuz and practical arrangements to restore safe navigation".

Trump pauses immigrant visa process for applicants worldwide

US may also revoke business & tourism visas of almost 2,00,000 foreigners

Reuters

Washington, August 26

PRESIDENT DONALD Trump's administration has issued a pause on immigrant visa appointments for applicants globally during an ongoing immigration crackdown by the US government in Trump's second term in the White House.

A US State Department spokesperson said Tuesday it

launched a global training initiative at all US embassies and consulates worldwide and appointments for visa services will be adjusted to accommodate the training.

The crackdown has faced some legal setbacks. A US judge Friday struck down a Trump administration policy suspending the issuance of immigrant visas to applicants from 75 countries, saying that the policy exceeded Secretary of State Marco Rubio's statutory authority.

The State Department did not specify details on the training and its timeline, beyond saying the training aimed to help consular officers screen out applicants deemed likely to be-

come dependent on US public benefits and to ensure evaluation of visa applicants "comprehensively and consistently."

The administration is also preparing to revoke business and tourism visas of up to 200,000 foreigners who have applied for or are currently seeking asylum status in the US, making it the single largest mass revocation of visas in US history and likely to face legal challenges.

Unless challenged or revised, the State Department is expected to announce in the coming weeks the revocation of so-called B1 and B2 visas issued between 2016 and 2026 whose holders have sought asylum or are now seeking asylum.

• WHILE META WILL NOT UNDERGO A FUNDAMENTAL OVERHAUL, THE ACCORDS COULD PROVIDE A TEMPLATE FOR RESOLVING THOUSANDS OF OTHER LAWSUITS AGAINST SOCIAL MEDIA COMPANIES

Meta agrees to pay \$18 bn to settle lawsuits over children's social media addiction

Diana Novak Jones & Jonathan Stempel
Oakland, August 26

META PLATFORMS will pay up to \$18 billion and strictly limit how teenagers use Facebook and Instagram under a sweeping agreement with nearly all US states to resolve claims it designed those social media platforms to addict children.

The settlements announced on Wednesday end a federal trial over allegations Meta's products harmed children and the company misled the public about their safety. Four of the states — California, Colorado, Kentucky and New Jersey — were expected to seek close to \$200 bil-

lion in civil penalties. While Meta will not undergo a fundamental overhaul, the accords represent a sweeping effort to define how it serves young users.

It could provide a template for resolving thousands of other lawsuits against social media companies. Governments around the world are trying to curb children's access to harmful online content, including a ban in Australia on social media for children under 16.

"The focus of this case was to protect our kids," Colorado Attorney General Phil Weiser said in a statement. "The relief we are getting in this settlement is very meaningful and well beyond what any court has ordered or is

likely to order."

Meta agreed over the next decade to restrict teenagers' use of Facebook and Instagram to two hours a day and block all usage from midnight to 6 am, absent parental consent.

These limits could be tightened if the social media platforms Snapchat, TikTok and YouTube adopt similar terms. Meta will also disable most push notifications to teenage users during school hours of 8 am to 3 pm and enhance measures to prevent children from accessing age-restricted content.

The settlement does not require Meta to abandon personalized recommendations or targeted advertising. Meta de-



Instagram CEO Adam Mosseri arrives to testify in the landmark case over social media harm to children, in Los Angeles. FILE

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1fornia-based-company.

"Ensuring teens have a safe and productive experience on our platforms is an absolute im-

perative for Meta," the company said in a blog post. "We want to get this right for parents and teens." The settlements include maximum payments of about \$17.7 billion to 48 US states, Washington, Puerto Rico, American Samoa and the Northern Mariana Islands.

California could receive a \$2.2 billion payout, while New York and Texas could each receive more than \$1 billion.

Some states will deposit funds they receive in general accounts while others will earmark portions to address children's mental health. Meta guaranteed payments of about \$12.7 billion, with another \$5 billion continuing on whether Snap Inc's

Snapchat, ByteDance's TikTok and Alphabet's YouTube impose similar protections for children. Those companies were not available for comment.

"This is a big deal," said James Speta, a Northwestern University law professor who specializes in telecommunications and internet policy.

"Meta and other companies were facing pressure to change business practices whether or not they lost the lawsuits, from the public and from Congress and state legislatures," he continued. "These restrictions will change experience on Instagram and Facebook, and are designed to reduce engagement."

Wednesday's settlements

also call for Meta to pay \$459 million to resolve states' privacy claims related to the Cambridge Analytica scandal, where a British consulting firm collected personal data of Facebook users without authorisation.

Instagram head Adam Mosseri had begun testifying, and Meta Chief Executive Mark Zuckerberg had been expected to testify. At a Wednesday hearing, Gonzalez Rogers called the settlement "a good step forward" and said she expected to grant approval. "I don't want to suggest there's anything with this agreement that I am particularly concerned with," the judge said. "I am quite happy to not have to finish up this trial." REUTERS

US’ HANDLING OF ITS RISING BORROWING COST HAS PUT MARKETS ON EDGE

As US debt hits \$40 trillion, all eyes on Fed’s Warsh at Jackson Hole

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 26

THIS WEEK, some of the most important policymakers and economists in the world will gather in Wyoming for the annual Jackson Hole Economic Policy Symposium, hosted by the Federal Reserve Bank of Kansas City.

And while the three-day event starting Thursday is always keenly eyed, this year’s edition has assumed even more importance given the events that have occurred in the last couple of months.

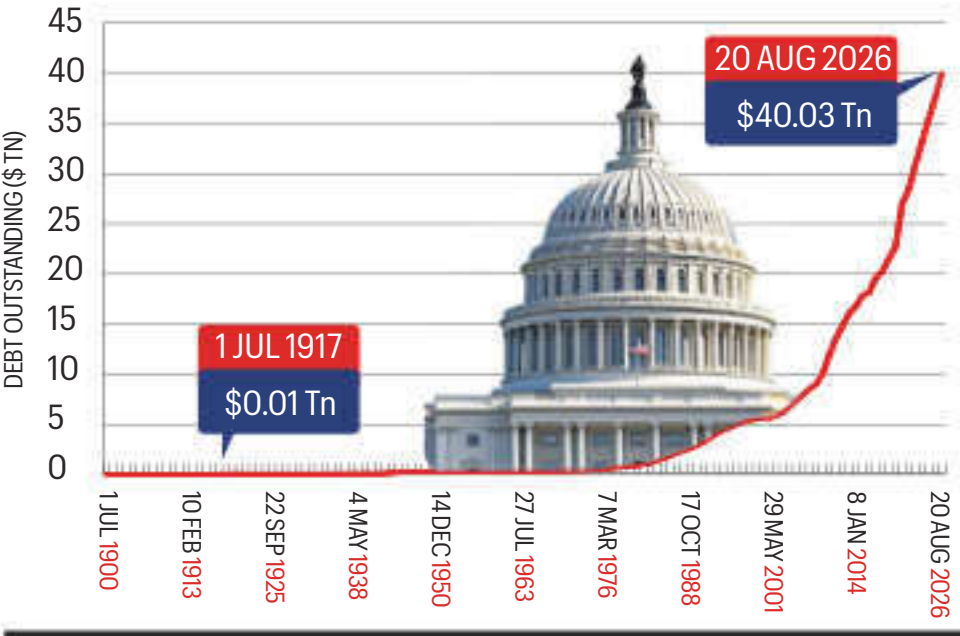
In what will be his first speech as the Chairman of the US Federal Reserve, Kevin Warsh on Friday will deliver the keynote remarks. While pressure is on Warsh to communicate better, expectations are not high. “Given Warsh’s approach to communication so far, he may provide even fewer clues on near-term monetary policy than markets currently expect,” Tepei Ino, Tokyo Head of Global Markets Research at MUFG Bank, said on Monday.

Bond buyback

Tensions have been high in global financial markets over the last couple of months, with matters coming to a head last week when the US’ total debt crossed \$40 trillion, or about 120% of its GDP.

It has taken less than five years for the US debt to reach this point after breaching \$30 trillion in January 2022. Revenues have taken a hit from President Donald Trump’s 2017 tax cuts, while spending surged

How US’ debt has spiralled



SOURCE: US DEPARTMENT OF TREASURY

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 borrows to bridge the difference between its income and expenditure — have been a major issue for the US government. High bond yields mean interest rates in the economy stay elevated, which weighs on economic activity.

In an attempt to cool long-term yields, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent last week said the government would buy back at least double the bonds it had already said it would.

These bond buybacks — done to improve trading by removing bonds that aren’t bought or sold regularly — are supposed to take place in the eight weeks starting September 9, a period that coincides with the US midterm elections.

Yield problem

Buying back bonds increases demand for them, which raises their price. Since bond prices and yields move in opposite directions, a rise in prices reduces yields.

Bond yields — which is the cost at which the government

borrows to bridge the difference between its income and expenditure — have been a major issue for the US government. High bond yields mean interest rates in the economy stay elevated, which weighs on economic activity.

On February 27, the day before the US and Israel attacked Iran, the 10-year bond yield was 3.97%, while the 30-year bond was trading at 4.64%.

On August 17, the day before US debt hit \$40 trillion, the 10-year yield was 4.72% and the 30-year at 5.31% — the highest in almost 20 years.

Bond yields have risen despite receding expectations of an interest rate hike by the US Federal Reserve. While this seems counter-intuitive, there are good reasons for it: elevated oil prices have worsened the inflation outlook, there is lack of clarity over the Fed’s future moves, debt is rising rapidly, supply shocks are becoming

more frequent, and the AI boom’s funding requirement is rivalling the government’s financing needs and pushing up borrowing costs.

Bessant’s announcement on August 19 that these bond buybacks would be doubled led to an immediate fall in yields — only for them to rise again the next day. On Tuesday, they were trading at 4.7% and 5.23%, respectively.

From New York to Tokyo

This is not the first step the Trump administration has taken to contain US bond yields. Late July, the US sold euros and bought the yen to prop up the Japanese currency, which had slumped to a 40-year low of 164-per-dollar. But why is the yen the US’ headache? For Japan to stabilise its currency, it would have to sell dollars and buy the yen. And it can only get hold of dollars by selling some of the US government bonds in its possession — which would push down prices of these bonds and raise US yields. Japan, as it turns out, owns the most US government bonds: \$1.12 trillion of it as of June, having sold \$123 billion of them since February.

To help Japan — and indirectly, itself — the US assisted in the defence of the yen.

Fiscal credibility

The problem with Bessant’s plan to lower US yields is markets’ lack of confidence in it. According to economists, the only long-term solution to high bond yields is a credible blueprint to

improve government finances, with interest payments now making up 15% of all spending at the federal level.

“...ultimately, policymakers will eventually need to address the deficit by raising taxes or cutting expenditure,” ANZ economists said Monday.

But room to cut spending is limited, with ANZ estimating around 60% of federal spending is mandated by existing legislation. Another 12-13% or so is defence spending, which is set to rise.

Dollar debasement

Given all of the above, markets think a weaker dollar lies ahead. According to Chen Zhao, Chief Global Strategist at Oxford Economics’ Alpine Macro, while controlling bond yields is not unusual, it can have its costs, with the direct impact being a fall in the dollar’s value.

“Importantly, the (yield) curve management, together with the joint currency intervention with Japan to prop up the yen last month, suggests that the US government does not mind having a weaker dollar,” Zhao said on Monday.

A weaker dollar also encourages the dollar debasement trade that became popular in 2025 and led to the historic rise in the price of gold. A weaker dollar makes commodities that are priced in the US currency cheaper. But if the dollar weakens, what happens to US inflation? This question brings us back to Warsh and his speech at Jackson Hole on Friday.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

PSU banks more efficient than private peers: EAC-PM

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, August 26

IN A surprising find, an analysis by the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) has found that government-run banks are more efficient than private banks, with the last three years in particular seeing public sector lenders improving their position.

In a paper titled ‘Reforms, Efficiency, and Productivity of Indian Banking Sector in the Last Decade: A DEA Approach’, authors Soumya Kanti Ghosh and Tapas Kumar Parida found that “contrary to popular perceptions”, the efficiency of public sector banks (PSBs) stood at 93.12% in 2025-26.

In comparison, private banks were operating at 86.02%. Foreign banks were at 85.88%. An efficiency score of under 100% means the bank can produce the same output by reducing its inputs.

For instance, if the efficiency score of a bank is 85%, then it can reduce its inputs by 15% (100% minus 85%) and still have the same output.

Over the 12-year period from 2014-15 to 2025-26, the study found PSBs to be more efficient than their private peers,

with a score of 88.53% as against 85.62%. Foreign banks scored the highest, with 88.98%. However, their efficiency score has declined sharply from 95.86% in 2014-15.

DEA refers to data envelopment analysis, a method used to understand performance. It measures the relative efficiency of decision-making units that produce the same goods or services.

Apart from being a part-time member of the EAC-PM, Ghosh is the State Bank of India’s Group Chief Economic Advisor. Parida is an economist in SBI’s Economic Research Department.

The unexpected finding comes days after Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman told officials of state-run banks that they had to raise their ‘cool’ quotient in the eyes of the country’s youth without sacrificing the prudence the business requires.

The Finance Minister had also said that PSBs “still give the impression of a government bank”.

HSBC, JPMorgan, SBI, HDFC on top

While several banks clocked the maximum efficiency score of 100% in 2025-26, only two

maintained that score across the 12 years covered by the paper: HSBC and JPMorgan Chase. As per Ghosh and Parida, the efficiency of foreign banks is better than domestic ones “mostly due to their prevalent business models”.

Among private lenders, HDFC Bank was the most efficient from 2014-15 to 2025-26, with a score of 97.54%. SBI, at 97.49%, was only marginally behind, the leader among PSBs. Interestingly, IDBI Bank — which the government has been trying to sell for years — has been the seventh-most efficient bank over the last 12 years, with SBI being the only PSB to rank ahead of it.

A variety of factors can affect the efficiency scores of any bank. For instance, the lowest score of any of the 47 banks examined by Ghosh and Parida was for DBS Bank India’s 40.12% in 2021-22. This, the paper said, may be due the merger of Laxmi Villas Bank with DBS Bank India in 2020.

“PSBs are relatively more efficient than private banks except FY19-FY22, which may be due to merger and rationalisation of business, branches, and employees,” the paper added.

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